ChatGPT Quick Start Guide.

Small steps for higher education: organize your work, pick the right settings and let ChatGPT handle the repeats.

YOUR FIRST WEEK

Day 1 Create a project with instructions and one file

Day 2 Find the model and effort controls

Day 3 Set one scheduled task and check its result

Full checklist on page 6.

GET THE APP

01 Get the official ChatGPT app and sign in with your .edu account

Install ChatGPT on your computer first. The desktop app has the full set of features. Skip search results and ads, which often point to look-alike apps, and type the address below into your browser.

01
On your computer, type chatgpt.com/download into the browser address bar.

02
Download and install the app for Mac or Windows. On Windows, the Microsoft Store listing must show OpenAI as the publisher.

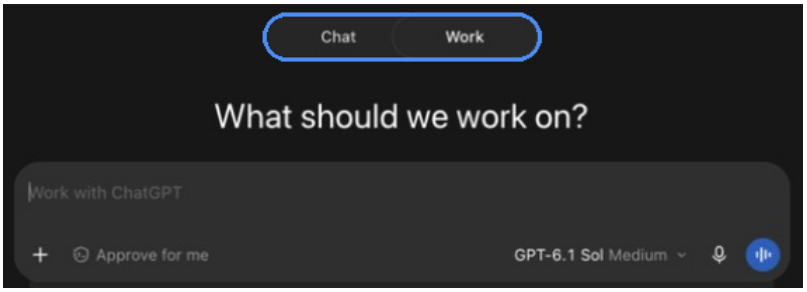
03
Open the app and choose Log in. Enter your full campus email address, the one ending in .edu.

04
Finish your campus sign-in. Check that your school's workspace name shows in the profile menu.

- Signed in with a personal email? Log out and sign in again with your .edu address so you get your campus plan and its data rules. Want it on your phone later? In the App Store or Google Play, install ChatGPT only when the publisher is OpenAI.

CHOOSE A MODE

02 Chat or Work? Pick the mode at the top of the screen



Find the Chat | Work switch at the top center of the ChatGPT home screen. Click either side to change modes.

CHAT
Talk it through
Questions, quick drafts and explanations. You stay in the conversation and steer each reply.

WORK
Hand off a job
Multistep tasks that produce a finished file, such as a report or slide deck. ChatGPT plans, uses your tools and reports back.

QUICK WIN Connect an approved document service, find five recent documents and ask for a one-line summary of each.

ORGANIZE

03 Put each ongoing job in a Project

A Project is a folder for chats, files and instructions about one job. Every new chat in it starts with that context, so you stop re-explaining.

Stop repeating yourself	Keep files in reach	Keep work separate
Write project instructions once, such as audience, tone and format. Every chat in the project follows them.	Upload the syllabus, policy or template once. ChatGPT draws on it in every project chat.	Project-only memory keeps a project's chats apart from your other conversations. Shared projects always use it.

01
Pick one recurring job, such as a course, committee or weekly report.

02
Create a project and name it after that job.

03
Add two or three reference files and a few lines of instructions.

04
Move related chats into the project. They pick up its instructions and files.

- Share a project with Edit or Chat access when a colleague needs the same context. Use approved, de-identified files and follow your student-data policy.

PICK A MODEL AND EFFORT

04 Match the model to the work. Start at low effort.

LOW	LOW OR MEDIUM	HIGHER, PLUS REVIEW
Narrow and repeated	**Judgment across sources**	**Consequential decisions**
Try GPT-6 Luna at Low for sorting, extraction or a task with a clear right answer.	Use GPT-6.1 Sol at Low or Medium for reports, reconciling documents and multistep work. Use the lowest effort that passes your check.	Increase effort when needed and add human review. Keep scope explicit. Consult your campus policy and the current Model Value Map.

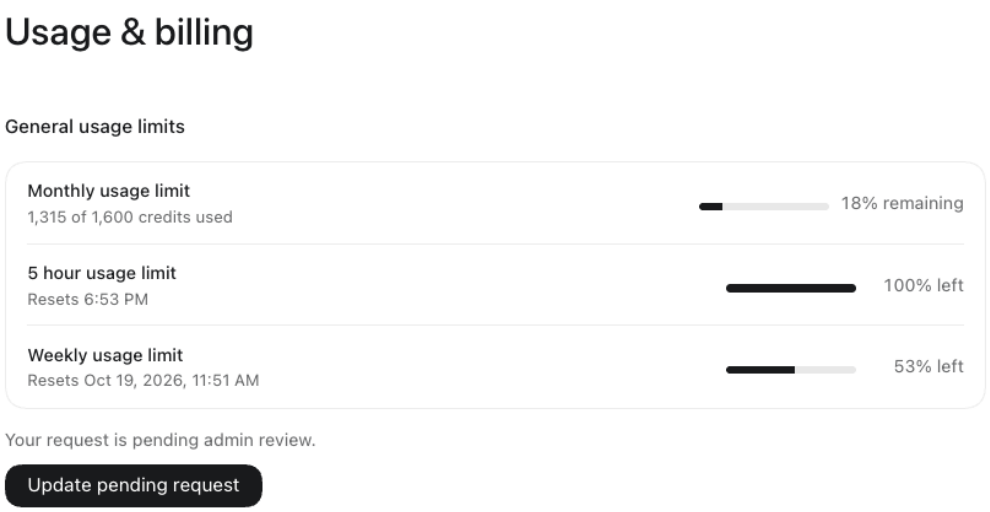
Open the AI Model Value Map

Raise effort only after a result fails your check. Higher effort takes more time and usage. Menu labels and models vary by account and campus settings.

CHECK YOUR ALLOWANCE

05 Work and Codex share usage. Check what is left.

In the desktop app, open your profile menu > Settings > Usage & billing. Check that you are in CES ChatGPT. The monthly credits, five-hour limit and weekly limit are separate controls; read each remaining amount and reset time.



Example from October 15, 2026: 285 monthly credits remain (1,600 minus 1,315), about 18%. Your balance, limits and reset times will differ.

- This allowance covers ChatGPT Work and Codex on plans that share credits. Regular Chat has separate limits. Credits are billing units, not tokens or a fixed number of messages. If a limit is reached, follow the reset or request options shown in your account; campus settings determine access.

SCHEDULED TASKS

06 Let ChatGPT show up on a schedule

MON Open items and deadlines.	**WED** Find stale documents in an approved shared folder.	**FRI** Draft a weekly update for review.

01
Open Scheduled when available, or describe the task and when it should run.

02
Choose a one-time or recurring schedule. Supported connected apps may offer event triggers.

03
Review the account, sources, instructions and permissions before relying on a run.

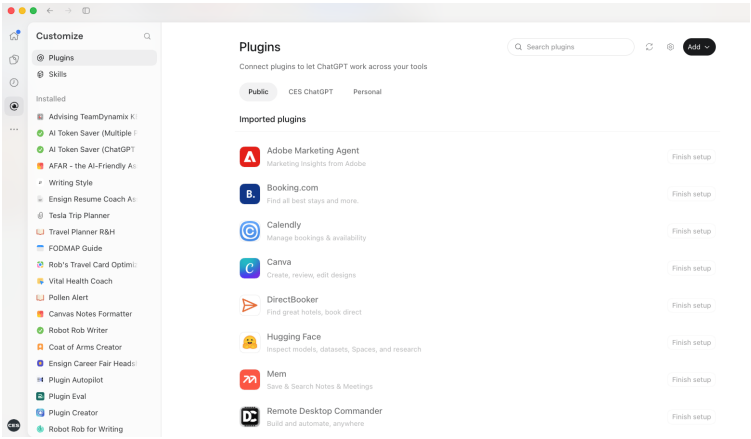
04
Check results and paused tasks in Scheduled.

- Computer-bound tasks need that device available. Cloud tasks have different requirements. If a task's model retires, update it before the next run.

FIND PLUGINS

07 Open Customize > Plugins

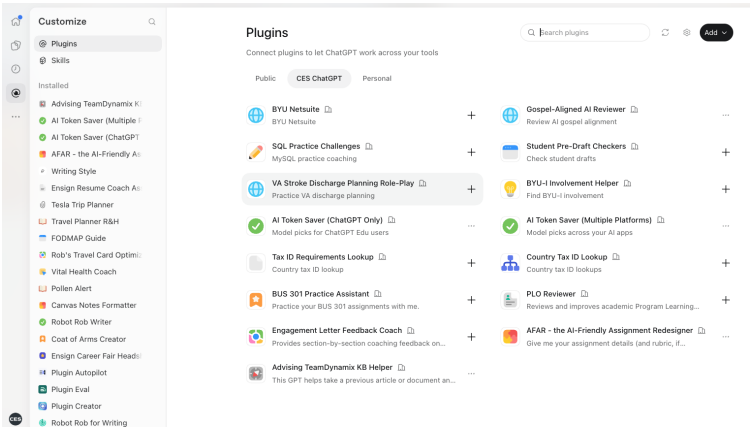
In the desktop app, select Customize in the left rail, then Plugins. Public shows the public directory. Personal shows plugins you created or received.



Use Search plugins to find a tool. Switch from Public to CES ChatGPT to see your workspace collection.

YOUR CES COLLECTION

08 Choose CES ChatGPT, then add a plugin



CES ChatGPT is the workspace collection. Shared tools, including former custom GPTs, appear here as plugins.

Open the CES setup guide

Install once, then select it in the chat where you need it. Availability and app permissions depend on your workspace.

01
Select CES ChatGPT. Open the plugin or use its + button, then choose Install plugin if prompted. Complete any required app connection.

02
Start or open a chat in Work. Type @ and select the installed plugin, or use + > Plugins where shown. Then describe the task.

03
For example, select AI Token Saver (ChatGPT Only) and ask: Help me choose a model and effort for this task. In a supported Codex task view, use Sources > Use plugins.

FIND USEFUL TOOLS

09 Start with the work you already do

GOOGLE DRIVE, GMAIL, OUTLOOK	CONSENSUS, QUIZLET	CANVA
Documents and email	**Research and study**	**Design**
Find an approved document, summarize a thread or draft a reply.	Explore research or build practice flashcards, where available. Check sources and accuracy.	Turn an outline into an event flyer, where available. Review the result before sharing.

- Also check Calendar, SharePoint, Slack, Teams and Notion. Availability varies. Use approved campus services and de-identified examples; follow your student-data policy.

MAKE, BUILD OR BORROW

10 Turn a task you repeat into a skill

Make a skill	**Make a plugin**	**Install one**
You repeat a focused task, such as a weekly update or a document review.	A workflow needs connected services or a bundle your team can reuse.	Search the Plugins directory before building a tool that already exists.

01
Name one repeated task and its required result.

02
Use Skill Creator where available. Describe the goal, steps and output format.

03
Test with de-identified examples and refine the instructions.

04
Share where your workspace permits. Name a maintainer and provide example prompts.

- Good first skills: meeting notes to action items, policy-template checks or clearer help articles.

HABITS FROM A WORKING SETUP

11 Six habits that make AI more useful

1 Name the task, the tools and the result you want.	**2** Ask ChatGPT to challenge your request if it is unclear.	**3** Keep a short handoff in each project: done, next and open questions.
4 Verify facts and saves before you rely on them.	**5** Search for an existing tool before you build one.	**6** Add one new habit at a time.

KNOW THE DIFFERENCE

12 A skill handles a task. A plugin bundles a workflow.

	Custom GPT	Skill	Plugin
PURPOSE	A separate chatbot	Reusable task instructions	Skills, files and connected capabilities
TOOLS	Apps or custom actions	Uses tools available to the task	May include connected apps
SHARING	Existing GPT permissions	Account and workspace controls	Share intentionally; apps authorize separately

IF YOU BUILT CUSTOM GPTS

13 Move your GPTs to plugins before they retire

RETIREMENT Dec 11 2026	What moves	What needs attention	Your move
	Published GPT instructions become a skill. Reference files and supported connected apps can move with the plugin.	Custom actions and sharing settings need review or rebuilding. Existing conversations remain accessible.	When available, open My GPTs > Migrate to plugin. Test familiar requests in the same workspace before switching.

- Follow your account or campus notice. For affected Enterprise workspaces, October 26 is the planned end of new GPT creation.

ADVANCED

14 Ready for more? Codex works with code

Codex is a third mode for code, tests and repositories. Most people never need it. Try it once Chat and Work feel routine.

Write and fix code	Work in a repository	Automations
Describe a script or bug. Codex edits the files and runs the checks.	Connect an approved code repository and ask for a change you can review before it lands.	Codex automations run on their own schedule, separate from ChatGPT Scheduled tasks.

- Use Codex only with code and data your campus allows. Review every change before you use it.

Try these next.

ONE A DAY. TICK AS YOU GO.

- [ ] Create a project with instructions and one file
- [ ] Set one scheduled task and check its result
- [ ] Create one focused skill with Skill Creator
- [ ] Ask your campus admin what tools and data are allowed
- [ ] Find the model and effort controls
- [ ] Connect one approved app and summarize a document
- [ ] Run one multistep task in Work
- [ ] If you own custom GPTs, plan and test their replacement

SOURCES AND CURRENT GUIDANCE

Download ChatGPT
GPT retirement and migration
Scheduled tasks
Current model guidance
Projects in ChatGPT
Plugins and connected apps
Model specifications and API prices
Work and Codex usage limits
AI Model Value Map
Skills in ChatGPT
October Chat model release
CES plugin setup guide